

membranes of the ear, nose, throat, and digestive system. A well-tolerated herb, it can be given to children to clear lingering congestion and to treat chronic conditions such as “glue ear” and sinusitis. Throat and chest problems, especially those due to excess mucus, also benefit from this remedy. Ground ivy is also a valuable treatment for gastritis and acid indigestion. Further along the gastrointestinal tract, its binding nature helps to counter diarrhea and to dry up watery and mucoid secretions. Ground ivy has been employed to prevent scurvy and as a spring tonic, and is considered beneficial in kidney disorders.



Ground ivy is useful for many disorders of the digestive system.

Glycine max (Fabaceae)

Soy

Description Annual growing to 6½ ft (2 m). Has leaves with 3 leaflets, white or purple flowers, and pods with 2–4 beans.

Habitat & Cultivation Soy is native to south-western Asia, and is cultivated in warm temperate regions. The pods are gathered when ripe.

Parts Used Beans, sprouts.

Constituents Soy contains protein (about 30%), fixed oil (about 17%), including lecithin (2% or more), linoleic acid, and alpha-linolenic acid, isoflavones, coumestrol, sterols, saponins, vitamins, and minerals. Coumestrol and the isoflavones closely mimic estrogen within the body.

History & Folklore A staple food in much of Asia, soy has been used in China for at least 5,000 years. Soy was introduced in the United States in 1804 and has become a major crop in the South and Midwest. It is now one of the world's most important food crops.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Although soybeans and soy produce have little direct medicinal value, they are highly important as foods, providing unusually high levels of protein, lecithin, and essential fatty acids. However, the beans may have a protective role against cancer; notably breast cancer. Their significant estrogenic activity makes them a particularly good medicinal food for women going through menopause, helping to relieve symptoms such as hot flashes, and to protect against osteoporosis. In Chinese medicine, soybean sprouts (also highly nutritious) are thought to help relieve “summer heat” and fever.

Research Soybean is a remarkable nutrient, rich in protein, fats, and estrogenic substances, all of which make it an excellent food. The isoflavones, sterols, saponins, and fiber contribute to soy's protective activity against cancer; and countries such as Japan are thought to have lower levels of cancer because of the great quantity of soy produce eaten there. The isoflavones, coumestrol, and sterols are all phytoestrogens. These appear to inhibit estrogen within the body when estrogen levels are too high (for example, in menstrual disorders), and to compensate when estrogen levels are low (such as during menopause). Unrefined soybean oil contains high levels of lecithin and polyunsaturated essential fatty acids, which support healthy levels of blood fat such as cholesterol.

Gnaphalium uliginosum (Asteraceae)

Marsh Cudweed

Description Annual plant growing to 8 in (20 cm). Has narrow silver-grey leaves and tiny yellow flower heads.

Habitat & Cultivation Marsh cudweed is native to Europe, the Caucasus, and western Asia, and is naturalized in North America. It prefers damp areas, and is gathered in summer when in flower.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Marsh cudweed contains a volatile oil and tannins.

Medicinal Actions & Uses While little used medicinally today, marsh cudweed has astringent, antiseptic, and decongestant properties. In British herbal medicine, it is occasionally taken for tonsillitis, sore throat, and hoarseness, and for mucus in the throat, nasal passages, and sinuses. Marsh cudweed is used in Russia to reduce high blood pressure. It is thought to be antidepressant and aphrodisiac.

Related Species A North American relative, *G. polycephalum*, was used to treat respiratory and intestinal congestion, and was applied as a poultice for bruises. *G. keriense*, native to New Zealand, is also considered a remedy for bruises.



Marsh cudweed is commonly found in damp areas in Europe, North America, and Asia.

Gossypium herbaceum (Malvaceae)

Cotton

Description Biennial or perennial growing to about 8 ft (2.5 m). Has lobed leaves, large white or pink flowers, and seed capsules surrounded by fluffy white tufts.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to the Americas, Africa, and Asia, cotton thrives in warm temperate and tropical climates. It is widely cultivated for its fiber. The root and seeds of the plant are harvested in autumn.

Parts Used Root bark, seed oil.

Constituents Cotton root bark contains gossypol (a sesquiterpene) and flavonoids. Cotton seed contains a fixed oil, which is about 2% gossypol, and flavonoids. Gossypol causes infertility in men.

History & Folklore In India and the Middle East, cotton has been cultivated since the earliest times for its fiber and medicinal properties. The plant was particularly valued for its ability to induce menstruation. Cotton seed oil's contraceptive effect in men was first discovered in China when men became infertile after eating food cooked in the oil.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Cotton root bark is rarely used medicinally today. It was once employed as a substitute for ergot (*Claviceps purpurea*), the widely used labor-inducing herb. Cotton root bark is both milder-acting and safer in effect, stimulating uterine contractions and hastening a difficult labor. It also promotes abortion or the onset of a period, and reduces menstrual flow. Cotton root bark encourages the blood to clot and the secretion of breastmilk. Cotton seed oil is used to treat heavy menstrual bleeding and endometriosis.